

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Indian Music - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC solved practice workbook | Full standalone render | Original MCQs, PYQs, model answers and practice

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Indian Music - Solved Practice Workbook

This standalone workbook carries exactly 32 original MCQs with strict ABCD rotation, 12 objective/application PYQs with answer-key discipline, 5 direct solved Mains PYQs and 6 full original Mains answers.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

CORE UPSC MCQS

Q1. Which statement about shruti and swara is safest?

A. Shruti is the microtonal pitch unit, while swara is the usable note organised in musical practice. B. Shruti and swara are interchangeable terms for raga. C. Swara means only the seven ragas of Indian music. D. Shruti is the same as laya because both concern pitch.

Answer: A.

Explanation: A is correct because the core source moves from 22 shrutis to swaras and then to saptak. B erases the distinction, C confuses note with raga, and D confuses pitch with tempo.

Q2. Which pair is correctly matched?

A. Venkatamakhin - earliest Sanskrit treatise on music B. Matanga's Brihaddeshi - early text associated with defining raga C. Dattilam - first national academy for performing arts D. Bhatkhande - composer of Gita Govinda

Answer: B.

Explanation: B is correct. A is wrong because the earliest Sanskrit music authority in the source is Bharata's Natyashastra, while Venkatamakhin is associated with the melakarta system. C confuses a text with Sangeet Natak Akademi. D confuses Bhatkhande with Jayadeva.

Q3. Which statement best distinguishes thaat from raga?

A. Both are unsung parent scales with identical functions. B. Raga is the parent scale and thaat is the sung derivative. C. Thaata is an unsung parent scale without vadi-samvadi or emotional personality, whereas raga is a performed melodic entity with note hierarchy and characteristic movement. D. Thaata belongs only to Carnatic music and raga only to Hindustani music.

Answer: C.

Explanation: C is correct because it preserves the exact conceptual split. A and B reverse or flatten the categories. D is false because raga belongs to both traditions, though thaata is specifically a Hindustani pedagogic classification.

Q4. Which statement about tala and laya is correct?

A. Laya means the same as shruti. B. Tala is a raga with seasonal association. C. Tala is the emotional mood of the composition. D. Tala is the rhythmic cycle, while laya is the tempo that keeps time-span uniform.

Answer: D.

Explanation: D is correct. A confuses rhythm with pitch, B confuses rhythm with melody, and C confuses rhythm with rasa.

Q5. Which statement best captures the Hindustani-Carnatic comparison?

A. They share older theoretical roots, but differ in grammar, repertoire, patronage ecology and the way improvisation is organised. B. Hindustani alone has improvisation, while Carnatic is wholly fixed. C. Carnatic is simply the southern branch of Persian music. D. The two traditions differ only by language and nothing else.

Answer: A.

Explanation: A is correct because it keeps common roots and real differences together. B ignores Carnatic manodharma, C is historically crude, and D reduces the comparison to a single variable.

Q6. Which sequence best reflects the safe Carnatic concert order taught in the topic?

A. Tillana -> Varnam -> Alapana -> Neraval B. Varnam -> Alapana -> Neraval -> Kalpana swara -> lighter close such as Tillana C. Ghazal -> Dhrupad -> RTP -> Tarana D. Pakhawaj alap -> khayal -> qawwali

Answer: B.

Explanation: B is correct because it follows the source-owned Carnatic sequence. A reverses the opening and closing logic. C mixes Hindustani and Carnatic genres carelessly. D invents a false chain.

Q7. Which statement about dhrupad is safest?

A. It is primarily a twentieth-century light-classical form. B. It is best identified by harmonium-driven romantic lyrics. C. It is an older, grave Hindustani form marked by alap-led exposition and pakhawaj accompaniment. D. It is identical to thumri in structure and mood.

Answer: C.

Explanation: C is correct. A places dhrupad in the wrong chronology, B gives it the wrong musical profile, and D collapses two very different forms.

Q8. Which description best fits khayal?

A. It excludes improvisation and allows only fixed syllables. B. It is a Carnatic percussion form. C. It must always be devotional and Sanskritic. D. It uses short bandishes, allows wide improvisational play and commonly works through bada and chhota khayal.

Answer: D.

Explanation: D is correct. A is the opposite of khayal's imagination-based profile. B places it in the wrong tradition and genre. C over-restricts its lyrical world.

Q9. Which statement about thumri is safest?

A. It is a semi-classical form that often combines romantic and devotional expression and is historically linked to Kathak performance worlds. B. It is the oldest form of Vedic chant. C. It is a Carnatic melakarta category. D. It must be sung only by paired male vocalists with pakhawaj.

Answer: A.

Explanation: A is correct. B shifts it to the wrong era, C mistakes a genre for a classification system, and D wrongly imports a dhrupad-style profile.

Q10. Which description best fits tappa?

A. A slow meditative form built on long alap alone B. A fast, knotty style with quick turns of phrase, rooted in folk tradition and later refined in court culture C. A temple-only Carnatic hymn with no rhythmic edge D. A system of classifying ragas into 72 parent groups

Answer: B.

Explanation: B is correct. A ignores its speed and phrase-work, C misplaces it, and D describes melakarta rather than tappa.

Q11. Which statement is safest about tarana and related invention claims?

A. Tarana, qawwali, sitar and tabla can all be assigned with certainty to one inventor. B. Tarana is a purely literary genre with no rhythmic emphasis. C. Tarana is rhythm-driven and fast-patterned, while single-inventor claims around figures such as Amir Khusrau should be treated cautiously unless firmly documented. D. Tarana is another name for laya.

Answer: C.

Explanation: C is correct because it combines form identification with attribution caution. A overclaims, B removes tarana's defining feature, and D confuses genre with tempo.

Q12. Which combination is correctly matched?

A. Swami Haridas - first national academy of performing arts B. Bismillah Khan - sitar C. Venkatamakhin - Qawwali at Sufi shrines D. Sadarang - shaping khayal under Muhammad Shah

Answer: D.

Explanation: D is correct. A confuses a musician with an institution. B misidentifies Bismillah Khan's instrument; he is associated with the shehnai. C confuses a Carnatic theorist with a devotional form.

Q13. Which statement about the Carnatic kriti is safest?

A. It is a highly evolved composed song set to a raga and fixed tala, with the exam-safe structural sequence Pallavi - Anu Pallavi - Charana. B. It is merely another name for thaat. C. It always rejects sahitya in favour of pure percussion. D. It belongs only to Mughal court music.

Answer: A.

Explanation: A is correct. B confuses composition with classification, C reverses Carnatic emphasis on sahitya, and D shifts the form into the wrong historical ecology.

Q14. Which pair is correctly matched?

A. Annamacharya - devotional songs to Krishna as the only verified source-owned claim B. Annamacharya - sankirtanas in praise of Lord Venkateswara C. Tyagaraja - founder of Sangeet Natak Akademi D. Kshetrappa - shehnai maestro

Answer: B.

Explanation: B is correct because the local verified source explicitly ties Annamacharya to Venkateswara. A repeats the wrong deity. C invents an institutional role. D confuses a composer with an instrument performer.

Q15. Which statement should be preferred in an answer on Tyagaraja and Annamacharya?

A. They were clearly contemporaries in the same court. B. Both are safest to identify mainly through Mughal patronage. C. The safer distinction is that Annamacharya's Venkateswara-centred corpus is source-owned, while simplistic contemporaneity claims with Tyagaraja must be avoided. D. Tyagaraja's importance lies only in inventing the shehnai.

Answer: C.

Explanation: C is correct because it mirrors the routed 2018 caution. A asserts a false chronology, B shifts Carnatic figures into the wrong patronage world, and D is entirely unrelated.

Q16. Which example best shows ruler-composer-patron overlap?

A. Amir Khusrau's legendary instrument attributions B. Bettiah Gharana's bandish emphasis C. Borgeet in Assam D. Swathi Thirunal Rama Varma composing in both Hindustani and Carnatic styles while also patronising the Thanjavur Quartet

Answer: D.

Explanation: D is correct because it combines authorship and patronage in one figure. A is an attribution-caution case, B is a gharana feature, and C is a regional devotional-folk tradition.

Q17. Which statement about gharana is safest?

A. A gharana is a lineage-based transmission structure that preserves specialised musical skill, repertoire and style across patrons and generations. B. A gharana is simply any modern music school building. C. Gharana is the Carnatic word for melakarta. D. The term is used only for percussion instruments.

Answer: A.

Explanation: A is correct because it treats gharana as pedagogy plus patronage ecology. B reduces it to architecture, C confuses it with classification, and D confuses lineage with instrument category.

Q18. Which pair is correctly matched?

A. Patiala - strict rejection of thumri and ghazal B. Kirana - precise swara focus associated in the source with Abdul Karim Khan and later exponents such as Bhimsen Joshi C. Dagar - main khayal gharana of Mumbai D. Bhendibazaar - temple mural tradition

Answer: B.

Explanation: B is correct. A is the opposite of Patiala's profile, C misidentifies Dagar's dhrupad association, and D confuses a gharana with a painting category.

Q19. Which statement best corrects the Aurangzeb cliché?

A. Aurangzeb destroyed every form of music across India. B. Aurangzeb personally created the thaat system. C. Court singing was curtailed, but instrumental music, noble and household patronage, veena practice and music literature continued; later khayal also grew under Muhammad Shah. D. The period saw no change in patronage patterns at all.

Answer: C.

Explanation: C is correct because it preserves the Satish Chandra correction. A is exaggerated, B is false, and D ignores clear redirection of patronage.

Q20. Which statement about instrument classification is safest?

A. Ghatam belongs to the membranophone class because it is struck. B. Sufiana kalam is a member of the Tata Vadya family. C. Shehnai is a genre of Hindustani poetry. D. Instrument questions should be solved by asking what vibrates: string, air column, membrane or the body of the instrument itself.

Answer: D.

Explanation: D is correct because it gives the classification method. A ignores the membrane test, B confuses genre with accompanying instrument, and C misclassifies an aerophone as poetry.

Q21. Which of the following belongs to the Tata Vadya family?

A. Santoor B. Shehnai C. Tabla D. Ghatam

Answer: A.

Explanation: A is correct because the santoor is a string instrument, even though it is struck. B is Sushira, C is Avanaddha, and D is Ghana.

Q22. Which statement correctly identifies a Sushira association?

A. Mridangam with Bismillah Khan B. Shehnai with Ustad Bismillah Khan C. Ghatam with Hariprasad Chaurasia D. Santoor with Kathak

Answer: B.

Explanation: B is correct because the shehnai is a wind instrument and Bismillah Khan is its iconic modern exponent in this topic. A assigns the wrong instrument, C confuses Ghana and Sushira, and D does not describe a core source-owned association.

Q23. What is the safest test for separating Avanaddha from Ghana instruments?

A. Whether the instrument is used in North India B. Whether the instrument accompanies devotion C. Whether a stretched membrane produces the sound; without the membrane, a struck instrument such as ghatam belongs to Ghana, not Avanaddha. D. Whether the instrument is ancient

Answer: C.

Explanation: C is correct because the membrane test is the decisive classification rule. A, B and D are secondary or irrelevant factors.

Q24. Which combination is correctly matched?

A. Mridangam - Hindustani court khayal marker B. Dotara - Kashmir court instrument only C. Gogona - Rajasthan Manganiyar bow-string instrument D. Santoor - Jammu and Kashmir; associated in the source with Sufiana kalam

Answer: D.

Explanation: D is correct. A reverses Carnatic/Hindustani placement, B ignores the Baul-Bengal association, and C confuses an Assamese wind-based folk instrument with the Rajasthani kamaicha world.

Q25. Which statement about Baul is safest?

A. Baul refers both to a Bengali religious-mystic current and to a folk song tradition shaped by Bhakti and Sufi influences. B. Baul is simply another name for Bharatanatyam. C. Baul denotes only a Hindustani gharana. D. Baul is a purely instrumental Carnatic form.

Answer: A.

Explanation: A is correct because the source treats Baul as both social-religious current and song tradition. B, C and D place it in unrelated categories.

Q26. Which statement about qawwali is safest?

A. It is a type of temple-only Sanskrit hymn. B. It is a devotional performance tradition associated with Sufi shrines and usually sung with group support and instruments such as tabla, dholak and harmonium. C. It is identical to Carnatic kriti. D. It should be described with unquestioned single-inventor certainty.

Answer: B.

Explanation: B is correct. A places qawwali in the wrong religious and linguistic world. C confuses unrelated traditions. D ignores the explicit invention-caution rule.

Q27. Which statement is safest about folk music in this topic?

A. Pandavani should be treated only as a percussion instrument. B. Panihari is best explained as a Mughal album genre. C. Folk forms such as Pandavani, Panihari, Maand and Borgeet preserve region, labour, devotion and social memory rather than merely imitating classical music. D. Folk music has no analytical use in Mains answers.

Answer: C.

Explanation: C is correct because it captures function and social context. A turns a narrative performance into an instrument, B relocates a Rajasthani folk form into painting, and D ignores a major answer route.

Q28. Which conclusion about the relationship between classical and folk traditions is safest?

A. Folk survives only when it becomes khayal. B. Classical and folk never interact. C. Devotional forms automatically erase regional identity. D. Interaction, borrowing and fusion occur, but classical and folk should still be distinguished by setting, transmission and function rather than ranked by cultural worth.

Answer: D.

Explanation: D is correct because it preserves both contact and distinction. A and B are absolutist, while C ignores how regional devotional forms actually work.

Q29. Which statement about Gandharva Mahavidyalaya best fits the verified local evidence?

A. Vishnu Digambar Paluskar founded the first Gandharva Mahavidyalaya in 1901 at Lahore, and it later moved to Mumbai in 1915. B. It was founded by Bhatkhande in Delhi in 1926. C. It was the first name of Sangeet Natak Akademi. D. It specialised only in Western orchestral training.

Answer: A.

Explanation: A is correct and directly supports the 2025 routed PYQ. B confuses Paluskar with Bhatkhande and 1901 with 1926. C merges two different institutions. D invents a false scope.

Q30. Which institutional pair is correctly matched?

A. Sangeet Natak Akademi - founded in 1901 by Paluskar B. Sangeet Natak Akademi - 1952; SPIC MACAY - 1977 C. SPIC MACAY - first codifier of melakarta D. Prayag Sangeet Samiti - founded by Akbar

Answer: B.

Explanation: B is correct. A gives SNA the history of Gandharva Mahavidyalaya. C turns a youth movement into a musicological text. D moves a twentieth-century institution into the Mughal period.

Q31. Which statement best reflects the topic's treatment of modern public recognition?

A. Bharat Ratna chronology is irrelevant because public honours tell us nothing about modern cultural legitimacy. B. Once state honours appear, older gharana and temple histories become useless. C. The sequence Subbulakshmi (1998), Ravi Shankar (1999), Bismillah Khan (2001) and Bhimsen Joshi (2008) helps show how the modern state became a recogniser of musical prestige without cancelling older transmission structures. D. These honours prove that every famous musician's gharana can be filled from memory.

Answer: C.

Explanation: C is correct because it turns dates into analysis rather than trivia. A denies the analytical value of recognition, B wrongly says modernity erases earlier structures, and D encourages unsafe fabrication.

Q32. Which statement should be avoided in a UPSC answer?

A. When official keys are unavailable, concept analysis may be retained but the answer letter should be withheld. B. The repository's modern-musician bank is useful, but it does not justify adding unsupported biographical claims. C. Contested invention claims should be flagged as contested unless contemporaneous proof is available. D. Because the 2026 paper mentioned Pandit Mallikarjun Mansur, it is safe to supply a definite gharana from memory even though the canonical bank marks that route as a bounded gap.

Answer: D.

Explanation: D is selected because it is the unsafe statement. The topic explicitly treats the Mallikarjun Mansur route as a bounded gap and forbids filling it from memory. A, B and C are the safe controls: they restate the package's answer-key discipline, evidence discipline and attribution caution.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

VERIFIED OBJECTIVE / APPLICATION PYQS

PYQ 1. With reference to cultural history of India, consider the following statements: 1. Most of the Tyagaraja Kritis are devotional songs in praise of Lord Krishna. 2. Tyagaraja created several new ragas. 3. Annamacharya and Tyagaraja are contemporaries. 4. Annamacharya kirtanas are devotional songs in praise of Lord Venkateshwara. Which of the statements given above are correct? (CSE 2018)

Answer withheld pending official UPSC key

Concept analysis: The locally held official paper wording is available, but the final official key is not locally verified in the controlling ledger. The safest eliminators are that Annamacharya is securely tied to Venkateswara, while the contemporaneity claim with Tyagaraja is unsafe. The question tests composer-devotion mapping and chronology, not mere memory of names.

PYQ 2. With reference to Mian Tansen, which one of the following statements is not correct? (a) Tansen was the title given to him by Emperor Akbar. (b) Tansen composed Dhrupads on Hindu gods and goddesses. (c) Tansen composed songs on his patrons. (d) Tansen invented many Ragas. (CSE 2019)

Answer withheld pending official UPSC key

Concept analysis: The topic routes this question to Mughal court music and requires caution with invention claims. Local sources support Akbar's patronage and the deity-plus-patron profile of Tansen's compositions, while wider invention claims need more care. Because the final official key is unavailable locally, the package withholds the letter.

PYQ 3. Which Hindustani classical Raag is sung as an invitation to rain? (a) Raag Yaman (b) Raag Bahar (c) Raag Malhar (d) Raag Bhairavi (CAPF 2025)

Answer withheld pending official UPSC key

Concept analysis: The question tests season-raga association. Nitin's raga-time-season table and adjoining notes place Malhar in the monsoon/rainy cluster, whereas Yaman and Bhairavi belong to other emotional-time associations and Bahar is spring-linked. Since only the chapter-end reproduction is locally recoverable here and no local official CAPF key was separately verified, the answer letter is withheld.

PYQ 4. Man Kautuhal, a work on music, was prepared under the aegis of (a) Raja Man Singh of Gwalior (b) Tansen (c) Meera Bai (d) Amir Khusrau (CDS I 2024)

Answer withheld pending official UPSC key

Concept analysis: This is a patronage-text question. The topic's safe evidence links Raja Man Singh Tomar of Gwalior with compilation of Mankautuhal and with the advancement of Gwalior as a music centre. The answer letter is still withheld because the final official CDS key was not locally verified.

PYQ 5. Who among the following has written three works on the science of music called Sangitaraja, Sangita Mimansa and Sudha Prabandha? (a) Tansen (b) Ibrahim Adil Shah (c) Amir Khusro (d) Maharana Kumbha of Mewar (Geo-Scientist 2024)

Answer withheld pending official UPSC key

Concept analysis: The question tests musicological authorship rather than performance. The locally extracted source ties Maharana Kumbha to Sangeet Raja, Sangeet Mimansa and Shuda Prabandha, while the other options are linked to different traditions and texts. Without a locally verified final official key, the letter remains withheld.

PYQ 6. Who among the following is credited with the introduction and popularisation of Dhrupad form of music? (a) Raja Man Singh Tomar of Gwalior (b) Tansen (c) Naik Gopal (d) Shaikh Bahauddin of Barnawa (CAPF 2022)

Answer withheld pending official UPSC key

Concept analysis: The question tests dhrupad's patronage and performance history. The topic gives usable evidence on Raja Man Singh Tomar, Tansen and Swami Haridas, but the final official CAPF key was not separately verified in the local official bank used for this repair. Therefore no answer letter is shown.

PYQ 7. Which of the following statements about the musical culture in the 18th and 19th centuries in north India is/are not correct? 1. The period was marked by the growing eminence of Sadarang Neamat Khan who introduced the khayal form. 2. A large number of musicians moved out of regional centres to Delhi, where they hoped they would receive greater employment and patronage. 3. The period was marked by the formation of specific region-based gharanas. Select the correct answer using the code given below: (a) 1 only (b) 1, 2 and 3 (c) 2 only (d) 2 and 3 only (CDS I 2015)

Answer withheld pending official UPSC key

Concept analysis: The question combines patronage movement with gharana formation. The repaired topic directly teaches Sadarang's role under Muhammad Shah and the formation of named gharanas, but the official answer letter is not locally verified. Use the item as an application drill on patronage redirection.

PYQ 8. The community of people called Manganiyars is well-known for their (a) Martial arts in north-east India (b) Musical tradition in north-west India (c) Classical vocal music in south India (d) Pietra dura tradition in central India (CSE 2014)

Answer withheld pending official UPSC key

Concept analysis: This is a region-tradition identification question. The topic links the Manganiyars with Rajasthan and the kamaicha-backed musical tradition of north-west India. The controlling rule still forbids recording an answer letter without a locally verified official key.

PYQ 9. With reference to Dhrupad, one of the major traditions of India that has been kept alive for centuries, which of the following statements are correct? (i) Dhrupad originated and was developed in the Rajput kingdoms during the Mughal period. (ii) Dhrupad is primarily a devotional and spiritual music. (iii) Dhrupad Alap uses Sanskrit syllables from mantras. Select the correct answer using the codes given below: (a) (i) and (ii) (b) (ii) and (iii) (c) (i), (ii) and (iii) (d) None of these (CSE 2012)

Answer withheld pending official UPSC key

Concept analysis: This question tests precise form-knowledge. The repaired topic supports dhrupad's devotional-spiritual profile and its Sanskritic syllabic world, but it does not allow lazy chronology. Since no locally verified final official UPSC key is present in the controlling bank, the answer letter is withheld.

PYQ 10. The first Gandharva Mahavidyalaya, a music training school, was set up in 1901 by Vishnu Digambar Paluskar in (a) Delhi (b) Gwalior (c) Ujjain (d) Lahore (CSE 2025)

Answer: D.

Why D is correct: The locally held official Set-A paper gives the wording, and the locally held official Set-A answer key records Q18 = D. The core source independently confirms that Paluskar founded the first Gandharva Mahavidyalaya in 1901 at Lahore, before it moved to Mumbai in 1915.

Why the others are wrong: Delhi, Gwalior and Ujjain are all plausible distractors because of their strong music associations, but none is the locally verified founding city for this institution.

PYQ 11. Which one of the following Carnatic music ragas is similar to Raga Bilawal in Hindustani music? (a) Nat Bhairavi (b) Kamavardhini (c) Hanumatodi (d) Dheera Shankarabharanam (CSE 2026)

Answer withheld pending official UPSC key

Concept analysis: The official local paper wording is available, but the controlling ledger explicitly records only a provisional 2026 key. Solve it through thaat-melakarta equivalence, not through mood or time-of-day association, and do not print a final answer letter.

PYQ 12. Pandit Mallikarjun Mansur, the famous classical singer from Karnataka, represented the: (a) Agra Gharana (b) Gwalior Gharana (c) Patiala Gharana (d) Jaipur-Atrauli Gharana (CSE 2026)

Answer withheld pending official UPSC key

Concept analysis: This is the topic's explicitly bounded gap. The official local paper wording exists, but only a provisional key is locally present and the canonical bank itself says the Mansur gharana route is not safely closed. The correct exam behaviour is to withhold the letter and not invent a gharana from memory.

DIRECT MAINS PYQS WITH MODEL ANSWERS

PYQ-M1. What are the groups into which musical instruments in India have traditionally been classified? (CSE 2012)

Model solution

Indian musical instruments are traditionally classified by the principle of sound production rather than by modern concert usage. The four exam-safe groups are:

1. **Tata Vadya (chordophones):** sound comes from vibrating strings. Examples include sitar, veena, sarangi, tanpura and santoor.
2. **Sushira Vadya (aerophones):** sound comes from an air column. Examples include bansuri, shehnai and pungi.
3. **Avanaddha Vadya (membranophones):** sound comes from a stretched membrane that is struck. Examples include tabla, mridangam and dhol.
4. **Ghana Vadya (idiophones):** sound comes from the vibrating body of the instrument itself, without a membrane. Examples include ghatam, manjira and jaltarang.

The practical value of this classification is immense in UPSC. It prevents common errors such as placing ghatam under drums just because it is struck. The membrane test is decisive: if the sound comes from skin, it is Avanaddha; if the body itself vibrates, it is Ghana. Thus, traditional classification joins theory with clear identification.

PYQ-M2. What are the important similarities and differences between the Hindustani and Carnatic styles of classical music? (CSE 2009)

Model solution

Hindustani and Carnatic music are sister traditions with a shared older theoretical base but different historical ecologies.

Similarities

- Both draw upon the older grammar of swara, raga and tala.
- Both recognise melodic personality, improvisation and disciplined training.
- Both depend on oral transmission, though later institutionalisation widened access.

Differences

- **Classification:** Hindustani uses the pedagogic 10-thaat system; Carnatic uses 72 melakarta parent ragas with janya derivation.
- **Performance grammar:** Hindustani works through alap, bandish, taan and gharana idiom; Carnatic uses kriti structure, alapana, neraval, kalpana swara and RTP.
- **Patronage ecology:** Hindustani developed strongly through North Indian courts and regional lineages; Carnatic remained more closely tied to temple, devotional and later sabha institutions.

- **Major forms:** Hindustani highlights dhrupad, khayal, thumri and tappa; Carnatic foregrounds kriti, varnam, padam, javali and tillana.

The best conclusion is that their difference lies in organised grammar and patronage history, not in any simplistic foreign-versus-pure divide.

PYQ-M3. Write about Khayal music. (CSE 1997)

Model solution

Khayal is a major Hindustani classical vocal form whose very name suggests imagination or idea. It is based on short compositions called bandish and is widely valued because it offers large space for improvisation.

A typical performance works through two broad levels: **bada khayal** in slow tempo and **chhota khayal** in faster tempo. Compared with dhrupad, khayal gives less space to austere alap and more to taan, lyrical turn and performer-specific elaboration. This flexibility explains why gharana identity becomes especially important in khayal performance.

Historically, the form received generous patronage in North Indian courtly settings. The topic's safe evidence connects later khayal strengthening with Muhammad Shah's court and with composers such as Sadarang. Gharanas such as Gwalior, Kirana, Agra, Patiala and Bhendibazaar then diversified its delivery.

Thus khayal is best described as the Hindustani form in which disciplined raga grammar and imaginative elaboration meet most visibly.

PYQ-M4. What are the chief characteristics of classical music? (CSE 1990)

Model solution

Indian classical music is distinguished by grammar, discipline and improvisation working together.

- It rests on a codified pitch system: shruti, swara and saptak.
- It organises melody through raga, not through arbitrary tune-making.
- It organises rhythm through tala and laya.
- It depends on prolonged training, oral transmission and close teacher-student discipline.
- It allows improvisation, but within formal rules rather than without structure.
- It preserves named forms and lineages such as dhrupad, khayal and kriti traditions.
- It is historically tied to patronage institutions - temple, court, household, sabha and modern academy.

Therefore, classical music is neither rigid recitation nor free spontaneity. Its defining mark is disciplined creativity inside a recognised grammar.

PYQ-M5. Which instrument does Ustad Amjad Ali Khan play? (CSE 1982)

Model solution

Ustad Amjad Ali Khan is associated with the **sarod**.

In answer-writing, the stronger version is not to stop at the one-word reply. Sarod belongs to the **Tata Vadya** family because it is a string instrument. That extension shows both factual knowledge and classificatory understanding, which is always safer in art-and-culture answers than isolated name recall.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

Original Q1. Distinguish raga from scale and tala from beat. Why does this precision matter in UPSC answers? (10 marks, 150 words)

Model solution

Indian music demands conceptual precision. A **scale** is a simple ordered pitch set; a **raga** is much more. A raga has arohana-avarohana, note hierarchy such as vadi and samvadi, characteristic phrase or pakad, and often a rasa-time association. Similarly, a **beat** is a simple pulse, whereas **tala** is the structured rhythmic cycle within which performance unfolds. **Laya** is the tempo of that cycle, not the cycle itself.

This precision matters because UPSC often uses close options. If a candidate equates raga with scale, thaat with raga, or tala with beat, the answer loses both theory and application. Accurate terminology also strengthens Mains answers: it shows that Indian music is a codified art with grammar, not a vague emotional practice. Therefore, definitional accuracy is itself a scoring skill in this topic.

Original Q2. Explain how dhrupad and khayal represent both continuity and change within Hindustani classical music. (10 marks, 150 words)

Model solution

Dhrupad and khayal are best read together. Both are classical Hindustani forms built around raga, training and disciplined presentation. That is the continuity. Yet they differ in performance emphasis. **Dhrupad** is grave, alap-led, Sanskritic in flavour and closely associated with pakhawaj accompaniment and older devotional-courtly gravity. **Khayal**, by contrast, relies on shorter bandish, bada-chhota sequencing and far greater room for taan-led improvisation and performer-specific imagination.

The historical significance of this shift lies in patronage and taste. Dhrupad rose to major prestige in earlier courtly worlds including Akbar's time, while khayal later expanded under changed performance cultures and under figures such as Sadarang in Muhammad Shah's period. Thus change in form did not destroy continuity in grammar; it reorganised the same tradition around new expressive priorities.

Original Q3. Compare Hindustani and Carnatic music through grammar, patronage and transmission rather than through geography alone. (15 marks, 250 words)

Model solution

Hindustani and Carnatic music share an older theoretical inheritance, but their mature forms emerged through different musical ecologies. A strong comparison must therefore move beyond the lazy North-South label.

First, grammar. Hindustani music uses the pedagogic logic of **10 thaats**, while Carnatic music works through **72 melakarta** parent ragas and derived janya ragas. Hindustani performance often emphasises alap, bandish, taan and gharana-specific phrasing; Carnatic performance is more overtly composition-centred through kriti, yet retains powerful improvisation through alapana, neraval, kalpana swara and Ragam-Tanam-Pallavi.

Second, patronage. Hindustani music developed strongly through devotional, Sultanate, Mughal and regional-court settings. Carnatic music remained more tightly linked to temple, devotional and later sabha institutions. This difference of patronage shaped not only venue but also repertoire and memory.

Third, transmission. Hindustani music is deeply marked by the gharana system, where lineage identity preserves style and technique. Carnatic music also values lineage, but guru-shishya and composer-centred repertoire are often safer descriptors than rigid gharana language.

Conclusion: The two traditions are sister systems. They differ in organised grammar, patronage and transmission patterns, not in cultural worth. That is the exam-safe comparison.

Original Q4. Classify Indian musical instruments and show how instrument-identification can become a high-scoring prelims elimination tool. (15 marks, 250 words)

Model solution

Indian musical instruments are traditionally classified by the **mechanism of sound production**, and this method itself becomes an excellent prelims tool.

1. Tata Vadya (chordophones): Strings vibrate. Examples: sitar, veena, sarangi, tanpura, santoor. Even struck string instruments like santoor remain Tata because the vibrating string is the decisive element.

2. Sushira Vadya (aerophones): Sound comes from an air column. Examples: bansuri, shehnai, pungi. The association of shehnai with Bismillah Khan helps identification.

3. Avanaddha Vadya (membranophones): A stretched membrane produces the sound. Examples: tabla, mridangam, dhol. The membrane test is the decisive prelims trick.

4. Ghana Vadya (idiophones): The instrument's body itself vibrates. Examples: ghatam, manjira, jaltarang, khartal.

This classification helps eliminate traps. A ghatam is struck, but that does not make it a drum; without a membrane it belongs to Ghana. Sufiana kalam is a genre, not an instrument, though the source associates it with the santoor. Likewise, tabla belongs to Hindustani usage, mridangam to Carnatic. Thus classification converts rote memory into a reliable answer method.

Original Q5. Examine how temple, court, lineage and modern institution together shaped the historical continuity of Indian music. (20 marks, 250 words)

Model solution

Indian music survived because its centres of support changed without destroying its underlying grammar.

Temple and devotional worlds nurtured music through liturgical chant, bhakti singing and composer traditions. In Carnatic history, Annamacharya, Purandara Dasa and later saint-composer memory demonstrate how deity-centred composition created continuity.

Courtly patronage was equally transformative. Dhrupad, khayal and several semi-classical developments expanded under Sultanate, Mughal and regional courts. Figures such as Tansen, Raja Man Singh Tomar, Ibrahim Adil Shah II and later Sadarang show that courts shaped both repertoire and prestige.

Lineage transmission ensured survival beyond individual rulers. Gharanas such as Dagar, Kirana, Agra or Patiala preserved technique, repertoire and style through family memory and apprenticeship. Even where Carnatic music uses different labels, guru-shishya discipline performs the same civilisational function.

Modern institutions then redirected patronage. Gandharva Mahavidyalaya, Bhatkhande's institute, Prayag Sangeet Samiti, Sangeet Natak Akademi and SPIC MACAY widened access, visibility and legitimacy. Broadcast, concert culture and recording further shifted music into public space.

Conclusion: Indian music endured not because one patronage model lasted forever, but because the tradition successfully moved from temple and court to lineage and institution.

Original Q6. Discuss the place of folk, devotional and fusion traditions in Indian music. Why should a UPSC answer avoid both hierarchy and careless invention claims? (20 marks, 250 words)

Model solution

Indian music is not exhausted by classical grammar. Folk, devotional and fusion traditions reveal how sound carries society.

Folk traditions such as Pandavani, Panihari, Maand, Borgeet and Baul encode epic memory, labour, locality, season, devotion and regional identity. They are valuable historical evidence precisely because they are anchored in community life rather than court canon.

Devotional traditions such as bhajan, shabad, qawwali, haveli sangeet, kirtan and sopana sangeetham show how doctrine becomes public performance. They also bridge elite and popular spheres because ritual participation widens the audience beyond specialists.

Fusion emerges where classical vocabulary and social reach overlap. The source itself notes that classical and folk intermingle over time, especially through devotional pathways.

However, two cautions matter in UPSC.

First, do not rank folk below classical. Their difference is one of function, transmission and setting, not artistic inferiority.

Second, do not overstate invention claims. Several forms or instruments are popularly attributed to singular figures, especially Amir Khusrau, but the advanced source explicitly warns that such claims need documentary caution.

Conclusion: A mature answer treats Indian music as a layered sound-world of grammar, community and memory, while keeping evidence limits visible.